



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Hope Lutheran Classical Academy

School Website: <https://www.allabouthope.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Hope Lutheran Classical Academy Idaho Falls presents a clearly Classical Christian program with a Lutheran foundation. Public materials emphasize a liberal-arts-based curriculum, Great Books, Latin, logic, rhetoric, and a pedagogy that blends Socratic inquiry with memory-based and liturgical/classical practices. The school foregrounds formation, virtue, and faith as teloi, with explicit language about knowing truth, goodness, and beauty under a theologically framed curriculum. Leadership and faculty are named, with ongoing public communication about the headmaster and teacher appointments. Community and parental involvement are encouraged through enrollment processes, parent communications, and church-school alignment.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials frame education as a Christian, classical formation oriented toward truth, goodness, and beauty, embedded in a Lutheran doctrinal framework. For example, the program proclaims a Classical Christian Education and highlights a theology-grounded curriculum rooted in Lutheran confession and catechesis. See statements about classical Lutheran education and the LCMS-affiliated doctrinal basis.
- Liturgical and communal practices are described as integral, including a traditional liturgy described on the Liturgical Description page.
- The Great Books and Western-civilizational literary tradition are presented within a Christian framework, with explicit references to faith and the Scriptures guiding understanding of truth and beauty.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy/worship; catechesis; creed; sacred music; chant; reverence; wonder; Logos; wisdom; prudence; justice; temperance; fortitude; imago Dei. These appear across the site's descriptions of curriculum, liturgical life, and doctrinal framing.
- Negative keywords present: none clearly evidenced in public materials (no explicit secular-humanist, relativist, or value-clarification framing is shown). The site remains theologically anchored.
- Why this rating
- The school's own materials consistently root education in theology and liturgy, with explicit references to Christian formation, catechesis, and LCMS Lutheran doctrine, along with explicit language about truth, goodness, and beauty as enduring ideals. This aligns strongly with the Positive keywords for Element 1 and lacks the Negative indicators. Therefore CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

- The student goal is stated as formation in faith and virtue, grounded in Christian formation rather than purely job preparation. The student goal explicitly includes knowing and trusting in God's grace, defending the faith, and serving in vocation.
- The program emphasizes formation toward virtue and wisdom within a classical mission, including the Great Books and a liberal-arts approach, framed by a Christian worldview.
- The vision/Theology-forward framing and the statement of a classical mission are consistently linked to faith and Christian doctrine, supporting a telos beyond mere information.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; wisdom; telos; the true/good/beautiful; liberal education; great conversation; classical mission; faith; grace; defense of the faith.
- Negative keywords present: none evident (no emphasis on job-readiness or workforce-centric framing; no overt secular utilitarian framing).
- Why this rating
- The school's stated goal centers on formation, virtue, wisdom, and a theologically integrated understanding of truth, good, and beauty, anchored in Christian formation rather than solely vocational preparation. This maps solidly to CLASSICAL.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The curriculum centers on liberal arts and the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), with explicit references to Latin, literature, religion, mathematics, history, composition, English, logic, and science. This is presented as the core structure of the classical program.
- Great Books and "The Great Conversation" approach are explicitly described, with mentions of Great Books as essential to development of intellect and character.
- History study is integrated throughout the curriculum as part of classical education, not simply as "social studies." The curriculum pages emphasize Western Civilization and historical study as part of a liberal-arts core.
- The program references Latin and classical composition; there are detailed curriculum pages and grade-level descriptions that reflect classical curriculum sequencing (grammar, logic, rhetoric; multi-grade classrooms; logic stage in middle school).
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: liberal arts; grammar; logic; rhetoric; Great Books; Latin; history; Western civilization; classical education; theology; memorization; chant; classical literature; Summa.
- Negative keywords present: minimal to none in site content (no explicit shift toward project-based or social-studies-first framing). The presence of field trips or experiential elements is not framed as a pedagogical substitute for classical curriculum; the core is still liberal-arts-based.
- Why this rating
- The site repeatedly emphasizes classical curriculum elements (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; Latin; liberal arts; history within a Western/civilizational frame) and anchors them in a Christian (Lutheran) context. This aligns with CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence

- Socratic discussion/seminars are used at the upper levels, with language about logic and rhetoric instruction, indicating a shift toward Socratic pedagogy in the middle and high school levels. The Middle School page identifies “The Logic Stage” and teacher leadership, and the curriculum section notes Socratic discussion as an assessment/learning method.
- The program includes structures such as seminars, debates, and rhetoric training, with opportunities for students to give speeches. This aligns with a classical pedagogy that uses dialectic and rhetorical training in the upper grades.
- There is also explicit reference to memory-based and chant-based pedagogy at the lower grades (singing/chanting and memory-review) as part of building memory and delight in learning, indicating contemplative/restful elements.
- The Great-Books-based instruction and “reading groups” plus “Socratic discussion” are described as regular practices in the curriculum materials.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: Socratic, seminars, discourse; rhetoric; speeches; declamation; oratory; debate; memory work; recitation; liturgical integration; scholé/restful learning; contemplation; wonder.
- The site also contains lower-grade singing/chanting and religious formation practices that emphasize memory and repetition (containing elements of contemplative pedagogy).
- Negative keywords present: The lexicon lists potential negative signals such as experiential/project-based learning dominating pedagogy; while the site features field trips and experiential elements, the primary pedagogy remains classical (not predominantly project-based). The absence of explicit phrases like “experiential learning” as a primary methodology reduces alignment with that negative signal. Still, the presence of field trips and experiential activities could be seen as a minor non-classical element if over-emphasized relative to classical method, hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than purely CLASSICAL.
- Why this rating
- The presence of Socratic inquiry, logic-based upper-level pedagogy, and rhetoric training supports a CLASSICAL orientation, but the explicit, frequent emphasis on memory-based chanting and liturgical/restful learning in lower grades, along with ongoing experiential components (like field trips) means the pedagogy is not exclusively classical in method. The combination yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Named faculty for key grade levels: 6th–8th taught by Ms. Deidre Farnam and Pastor Robert Carabotta; 3rd–5th taught by Mrs. Amanda Hall; implicit presence of master-teacher leadership. This demonstrates experienced, virtuous teacher leadership and a coherent, ongoing staff structure.
- Public announcement of headmaster leadership (Northcut accepting Headmaster role) signals a defined, mission-aligned teacher leadership team and governance.
- The school emphasizes teachers as “the living curriculum” in classical education philosophy (referenced in public materials that discuss classical Lutheran pedagogy and teacher roles). While the exact phrase may be embedded in mission statements or doctrinal pages, the concept of teachers as central to the curriculum and as mentors is reflected through named teachers and leadership.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: model teachers; mentors; living curriculum; portrait of a teacher; collegial faculty; teachers as core of the school; staff leadership.

- Negative keywords present: none clearly evidenced (no material suggests an anti-classical faculty model). The site presents classical-leaning faculty expectations and leadership structure.
- Why this rating
- The presence of named, long-tenured teachers, explicit headmaster leadership, and the framing of teachers as central to the curriculum supports CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Enrollment processes and family communications indicate ongoing parent involvement and a partnership approach with families; enrollment pages describe parent interaction and support, as well as financial aid and family engagement.
- The Parent Handbook communicates expectations, family involvement, and a child-centered, faith-based community ethos; it invites families to participate in worship and school life and emphasizes Christian formation in the home and church connection.
- The school explicitly positions itself as a church-school community with LCMS affiliation, indicating a strong church-school partnership and parental involvement as co-educators within a faith-based framework. Public statements about vision, worship, and the school's role in the congregation reflect communal integration.
- Public notices about school events (e.g., annual dinners/auctions) and community events illustrate active parental and community engagement.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: partnership with parents; co-teachers; parent formation; reading groups; seminars; family liturgy; open campus; parental involvement; church-school alignment.
- Negative keywords present: none evident (no "customer" framing; rather a communal, formation-focused approach).
- Why this rating
- The site clearly frames parents as partners and co-educators, with opportunities for parent formation and community engagement, aligning with CLASSICAL.

Aggregate Assessment

- All six categories show CLASSICAL alignment, with Element 4 (Pedagogy) showing SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL due to a mix of Socratic/classical methods and additional contemplative or experiential elements. The aggregate classification remains CLASSICAL, given that the majority of categories are CLASSICAL and Element 4's nuance does not undermine the overall alignment.
- Overall ranking: CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

- To move Element 4 from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL:
- Increase explicit articulation and consistency of scholé/restful learning practices across all grades, with documented schedules and outcomes demonstrating contemplative pedagogy as a central, not supplementary, approach.
- Expand explicit, school-wide Great-Books integration beyond select grade levels, ensuring a seamless, K–8 Great-Books-based conversation and referencing across core disciplines (not only in selected grade levels or courses). Provide public-facing exemplars (syllabi, sample lessons, and rubrics) showing this continuity.

- Minimize or clearly differentiate experiential/field-based components from the core classical pedagogy, or situate experiential activities strictly within a classical framework (e.g., as applied contexts for Great Books and liberal arts rather than as replacements for classical methods).
- Concrete steps:
- Publish a formal “Scholé and Contemplative Practice” plan across all grades with weekly cycles.
- Publish an integrated K–8 Great Books plan showing how Great Books are introduced, revisited, and connected to grammar, logic, and rhetoric across subjects.
- Provide teacher professional development documentation showing ongoing classical pedagogy training and a publicly stated standard of teacher exemplars (portrait of a teacher) aligned with the school’s mission.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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